

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

THE ARCHITECT & WHISTLEBLOWER

- **CAPTAIN J. C. POWELL:** Confederate veteran, pragmatic prison captain, and complex moral actor. Inheritor of white Southern privilege, Powell enters the penal lease system believing in discipline, order, and paternalistic control. As he witnesses the state sell human labor for corporate profit, his internal conflict deepens—culminating in his decision to break ranks and publish his explosive 1891 tell-all, *The American Siberia*, effectively becoming the system's first major whistleblower.

THE SYSTEM & ITS POWER BROKERS

- **WARDEN MARTIN:** The original administrator of Chattahoochee—a ruthless opportunist who built a personal fortune through convict labor and torture, establishing structural abuses that echo across Florida's modern penal landscape.
- **SENATOR D. C. DAWSON (Composite Figure):** A powerful state politician and timber/railroad tycoon who views convicts strictly as non-depreciating state assets, representing the institutional nexus of capital, politics, and racial subjection.

THE CONVICTS (FACT & HISTORICAL RE-IMAGINING)

- **CY WILLIAMS (Convict No. 1) (Factual):** Black convict arrested as a young child for leading away a horse. Forced by early wardens to spend years carrying bricks across a yard, Cy embodies the generational trauma and racialized cradle-to-prison pipeline of post-Reconstruction law.
- **WALTER SHAVERS (Factual):** White convict whose intelligence and charisma make him a formidable leader. His fierce refusal to be leased out to corporate syndicates forces Powell to confront the illusion of his own authority.
- **MAUD FOSTER (Factual):** Refined Northern woman wrongfully convicted in Key West. Her tragic arc reveals how the legal system weaponized power against the vulnerable, regardless of class background.
- **SOL LOVE (Factual):** An imposing, cunning convict who leads a daring escape from a brickyard. His tragic death in hiding symbolizes the relentless, fatal pursuit of total autonomy.
- **ELIJAH "TEACH" WASHINGTON (Historical Fiction):** A literate Black convict and former Reconstruction clerk jailed on manufactured vagrancy charges. Elijah acts as Powell's covert collaborator and intellectual mirror, challenging Powell's racial biases and quietly documenting abuses alongside him.

HOLLYWOOD FILM TREATMENT

TITLE: *THE AMERICAN SIBERIA*

GENRE: Historical Drama / Political Thriller / Biopic

TONE: Gritty, atmospheric, uncompromising, and introspective (in the vein of *Killers of the Flower Moon*, *Spotlight*, and *12 Years a Slave*).

LOGLINE

In post-Reconstruction Florida, a reform-minded prison captain struggles to navigate his inherited racial privilege while managing a brutal convict lease system—until the horrors he witnesses force him to sacrifice his standing and publish a scathing whistleblowing exposé that lays bare the state's penal legacy.

THEMATIC FOCUS & HISTORICAL ARC

This narrative directly targets the foundational mechanics of Florida's early prison system:

1. **The Profit-Over-Life Mandate:** How state-sanctioned corporal punishment, lease-labor arrangements, and corporate greed built traditions of institutional neglect that resonate into modern corrections.
2. **Racial Privilege & Complicity:** Powell's gradual realization that his status as a white Southern officer grants him the luxury of moral hesitation, while the Black and destitute men under his command pay for state policies with their lives.
3. **The Whistleblower's Cost:** Transmutation of personal field notes into *The American Siberia*, framed as an act of institutional betrayal against the Southern political establishment.

ACT I: THE INHERITED ORDER (1876)

The Lease System Arrives

The film opens at the Live Oak train depot in 1876. J.C. POWELL, taking up his post as captain of the Florida convict lease camps, watches thirty emaciated men in irons step down into the dust. Among them are **CY WILLIAMS**, incarcerated since boyhood, and **ELIJAH WASHINGTON**, a former clerk whose literacy makes him an immediate target of suspicion.

Powell, raised in the racial hierarchy of the antebellum South, initially approaches his assignment as a civilizing mission. He believes that strict discipline, hygiene, and firm white paternalism can reform a broken system. He burns the prisoners' vermin-infested rags and issues clean clothes, convinced that his leadership will distinguish his camp from the infamous atrocities of **WARDEN MARTIN** at Chattahoochee.

INT. POWELL'S QUARTERS - NIGHT

POWELL writes in a neat leather ledger. Outside, the low

clinking of stride-chains echoes from the pine-log cell-house.

POWELL (V.O.)

Order is not cruelty. The state demands labor; I demand discipline. Under my watch, we shall be firm, but humane.

The Reality of the Pinetops

Powell's ideals collide with economic reality. State power brokers like **SENATOR DAWSON** view the prisoners not as human beings under state care, but as disposable labor leased to turn virgin pine forests into lucrative naval stores. When dysentery and malaria break out in camp Padlock, Powell requests medical supplies and reduced work quotas—only to be sternly reminded by Dawson that dead convicts cost the state nothing, but halted turpentine production costs thousands.

ACT II: THE CRUCIBLE OF PRIVILEGE (1880–1884)

Complicity & Confrontation

As the operations expand into swamp logging and brickyards, Powell finds himself enforcing policies he fundamentally detests. He oversees sweat-boxes and string-ups for men who fail to meet impossible daily turpentine quotas.

During an interrogation of **WALTER SHAVERS** following a strike against railroad contractors, Shavers confronts Powell on his hypocrisy.

INT. CELL-HOUSE - DAY

SHAVERS, hands bound, stares directly into Powell's eyes.

SHAVERS

You wear the uniform and speak of duty, Captain. But you sleep in a dry bed while men drown in palmetto mud to fill your bosses' pockets. You ain't reformin' this place—you're just its polite face.

The words rattle Powell. He turns to **ELIJAH WASHINGTON**, who secretly keeps duplicate records of deaths, beatings, and corporate kickbacks. Elijah quietly points out what Powell's privilege allows him to ignore: that the legal framework—from vagrancy laws to long sentences

for minor offenses like Cy Williams' childhood horse theft—is explicitly designed to construct a permanent, racialized labor force.

EXT. CAMP HILLYARD - NIGHT

Powell walks the perimeter with Elijah under heavy moonlight.

POWELL

The law must have its process, Elijah.

ELIJAH

The law gave you a gun and a salary, Captain. It gave
Cy Williams seventeen years for being ten years old and
near the wrong horse. That isn't law. That's a trap.

The Maud Foster Case

The arrival of **MAUD FOSTER**, a young Northern woman framed by land speculators in Key West, exposes the system's absolute indifference to justice. Powell attempts to secure her an early administrative release, but state officials refuse, using her presence as a spectacle to demonstrate "equal enforcement" while lining their pockets with lease fees. Powell realizes that his individual authority is an illusion—he is merely a middle manager for a state-sanctioned labor cartel.

ACT III: THE BREAKING POINT (1888–1890)

The Epidemic and the Cover-Up

A fatal epidemic of spinal meningitis ravages Camp Hillyard. Dozens of convicts die in agonizing spasms. When Powell compiles a detailed casualty report demanding an immediate state investigation and an end to the lease system, Senator Dawson arrives in camp accompanied by armed guards.

Dawson shreds the official report in front of Powell, informing him that the state legislature has already allocated the lease revenue for public infrastructure projects. Dawson reminds Powell of his standing, his social class, and his Southern legacy—warning him that turning against the state will render him an outcast, stripped of his reputation and livelihood.

INT. POWELL'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Powell sits alone in the dark. On his desk lies Elijah's
clandestine logbook detailing every unrecorded grave in

the pine woods, alongside Powell's own journals.

He realizes his privilege has given him two choices: remain silent and keep his status, or speak out and lose everything.

The Escape & The Evidence

SOL LOVE makes a desperate bid for freedom from the brickyard, preferring to take a bullet rather than endure another year under state lease. When Love's mortally wounded body is recovered, Powell refuses to log him as an "attempted escapee," officially recording his death as institutional homicide. Powell collaborates with Elijah to smuggle the complete set of logs out of the camp before state auditors arrive to confiscate the records.

ACT IV: THE WHISTLEBLOWER (1891)

Publishing *The American Siberia*

Flash forward to 1891. Powell, now retired from the service and ostracized by his former peers in Southern society, sits in a small room surrounded by years of notes, records, and correspondence.

He finishes the final pages of his manuscript: *The American Siberia; or, Fourteen Years' Experience in a Southern Convict Camp*.

INT. PRINTING PRESS - DAY

The heavy mechanical presses roll. Thousands of pages print, bearing the title: THE AMERICAN SIBERIA.

The publication sends shockwaves through the political establishment. Southern newspapers denounce Powell as a traitor to his region and class, while Northern outlets reprint his vivid accounts of whipcords, sweat-boxes, and corporate exploitation.

The Legacy

In a cinematic montage, the voice of Powell reading from his memoir overlays scenes of the people whose lives he documented:

- **CY WILLIAMS** walking out of the prison gates after seventeen long years, stepping onto a road that stretches into an uncertain future.
- **ELIJAH WASHINGTON** teaching young Black children in a rural classroom, using books purchased with funds Powell quietly provided.
- **MAUD FOSTER** boarding a steamship in Jacksonville, leaving Florida behind forever.

- Modern archival footage or cinematic fast-forwards transitioning from the 19th-century pine-log cell-houses to modern high-walled Florida correctional facilities—showing how the administrative lines, forced labor concepts, and solitary isolation practices introduced in Powell’s era cast a long shadow over contemporary corrections.

FADE OUT ON TEXT:

In 1891, J.C. Powell published "The American Siberia," exposing the atrocities of Florida's convict lease system to the world.

Though the lease system was eventually abolished in 1923, many of the operational practices, racial disparities, and disciplinary traditions established during this era helped shape the modern American prison landscape.

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Academic and Research Background

Jerald J. Cheesborough is a graduate student pursuing a Master of Arts in History at the University of Florida. He focuses his research on United States history, carceral history within the American South, and especially juvenile justice reform. His scholarly work explores Florida criminal justice history, including archival research into institutions like the Dozier School for Boys, alongside broader studies on labor systems and post-Reconstruction legal frameworks.

COPYRIGHT OWNERSHIP AND ASSIGNMENT AGREEMENT

This Copyright Ownership Agreement (the "Agreement") is entered into as of **July 24, 2026** (the "Effective Date"), by and between:

ASSIGNOR (Author/Creator):

- **Full Legal Name:** Jerald J. Cheesborough
- **Address:** 2724 NW 244th Street, Newberry, Florida 32669
- **Email:** jeraldcheesborough@gmail.com

ASSIGNEE (Owner/Entity):

- **Full Legal Name / Entity Name:** Jerald J. Cheesborough [or Entity Name, e.g., Jerald J. Cheesborough LLC]
- **Address:** 2724 NW 244th Street, Newberry, Florida 32669
- **Email:** jeraldcheesborough@gmail.com
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1. RECITALS

WHEREAS, Assignor is the sole author, creator, and original copyright owner of the work(s) described herein; and

WHEREAS, Assignor desires to assign and transfer all right, title, and interest in and to the Work, including the complete copyright, to Assignee under the terms set forth below.

2. IDENTIFICATION OF THE WORK

The work covered by this Agreement consists of the following creative material(s) (collectively, the "Work"):

- **Title of Work:** [Title or Description of the Work, e.g., Screenplay Treatment: The American Siberia]
- **Medium/Format:** [e.g., Written Text, Film Treatment, Screenplay, Educational Curriculum]
- **Completion/Creation Date:** July 24, 2026
- **Attached Materials:** [Jerald J. Cheesborough will provide all relevant research, documentation, photographs, academic literature etc... within a meeting with potential interested parties]

3. ASSIGNMENT OF COPYRIGHT AND INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY

In consideration of **\$10.00 and other good and valuable consideration**, the receipt and sufficiency of which are hereby acknowledged:

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2. **Sole Ownership:** Assignor is the sole legal and beneficial owner of the Work and possesses the full power and authority to enter into this Agreement and grant the rights assigned herein.
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This Agreement shall be governed by, construed, and enforced in accordance with the laws of the State of **Florida**, without regard to its conflict of law principles. Any dispute arising under or in connection with this Agreement shall be brought exclusively in the state or federal courts located in **Alachua County, Florida**.

IN WITNESS WHEREOF, the parties hereto have executed this Copyright Ownership and Assignment Agreement as of the Effective Date written above.

ASSIGNOR (Creator):

Signature: _____ *Gerald J. Cheesborough* _____

Printed Name: **Jerald J. Cheesborough**

Date: **July 24, 2026**

ASSIGNEE (Owner):

Signature: _____ *Gerald J. Cheesborough* _____

Printed Name: **Jerald J. Cheesborough**

Title: **Individual / Sole Member**

Date: **July 24, 2026**

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